

The three products and what they do

A plain-language guide to every feature, what it means, and whether it is available. Written 6 October 2026.

The idea in one page

Smart Assess Ja is one platform made of three products that share one school, one set of people and one list of topics. Each product has one job, and a feature belongs to only one of them:

Product	Its one job	Status
Smart Assess	Measure learning. Everything about setting, sitting, marking and analysing tests and exams, and the results that come out of them.	In use at Manchester
Smart Learning	Teach and recover learning. Lessons, lesson plans, study support, catch-up for absent students, and the Library. It acts on what Smart Assess finds.	Switched on at Manchester
Smart Play	Make practice engaging. Classroom games, duels and competitions. It never holds a school's official results.	Built, not yet switched on (shown as "coming soon")

The three share one list of topics (each topic has a permanent code), so a weak topic found in Smart Assess can lead to a lesson in Smart Learning or a game in Smart Play without any product reaching into another's data. Besides the three products there are school tools that every product relies on (attendance, timetable, staff management and so on). They are listed last.

What the status words mean

Status	Meaning
Live	Built, working and in use at Manchester.
On per school	Built and working, but a school has to be switched on for it (by us, in the owner console). Manchester has it unless noted.
Needs a database update	The code is built and tested, but a database update has to be run on the school first. Until then it stays hidden.
Built, not switched on	Finished and tested, but held back until we choose to launch it.
Planned	Agreed or proposed, not built yet.

Smart Assess

For assessments only: set them, sit them, mark them, and understand the results.

Building tests and exams

Feature	What it does and what it means	Status
Test and exam types	Pop quizzes, class tests, weekly tests, midterms, monthly, end-of-term and end-of-year exams. Also assignments, homework and group projects.	Live
Question types	Multiple choice, true/false, short answer, fill in the blank and essay. Questions can carry an image, audio or video.	Live
Maths notation and calculator	A toolbar and symbol picker for writing equations and symbols, and an optional on-screen scientific calculator inside an exam.	Live
Question bank	A teacher saves a question once and reuses it in future tests. Questions can be tagged to a topic from the shared topic list.	Live
Import questions from a PDF	The AI reads a PDF of an exam and turns it into questions. The teacher reviews every one. Limited per teacher each month.	Live
Polish a question with AI	The AI suggests clearer wording for a question. The teacher decides whether to use it. Limited per teacher each month.	Live
Exam settings	Time limit, pass mark, access password, questions per page, the dates it is open, target year, and shuffled answer options.	Live
Marking points for essays	A teacher writes what a good essay earns marks for, and how many. Marking then gives a box for each point. Optional.	Needs a database update

School exams (standardised across a department)

Feature	What it does and what it means	Status
Team lead exams	A team lead drafts a standardised exam (monthly, midterm, end of term) and submits it for review.	Live
Vetting and publishing	Heads of department review, comment on and approve exams, then publish them to chosen classes. Several heads of one department can act together.	Live
Exam sections	An exam can be split into sections, for example one for multiple choice and one for essays.	Live

Sitting an exam: security and fairness

Feature	What it does and what it means	Status
Secure exam page	Switching to another tab is counted and logged, pasting is blocked, and a student can be signed in on only one device at a time.	Live
Desktop app (kiosk mode)	A Windows and Mac app that locks the screen to the exam while it is being sat.	Live
Protected against dropped connections	Answers are saved on the device while a student works, so a lost connection does not lose the exam. Late submissions are still accepted but flagged for the teacher.	Live

Feature	What it does and what it means	Status
Server-side protection	The database controls when an exam can start, how long it runs and who can change marks, so a student cannot alter their own answers or scores.	Needs a database update
Student accommodations	A teacher or admin can switch on supports for a student, such as read-aloud.	Live
Writing integrity flags	For essays, the platform notes how the answer was typed (for example unusually uniform typing or text that appeared in one jump). A teacher can ask for an AI second opinion. These are only prompts. A person always decides.	Live

Marking and results

Feature	What it does and what it means	Status
Automatic marking	Multiple choice, true/false, short answer and fill-in answers are marked as soon as a student submits. Short answers can use marking points with keywords.	Live
Grading essays	A teacher marks essays on a dedicated page, or student by student on a review page, and can override any mark.	Live
Releasing results	Results are held back until the teacher releases them. Students are emailed when results are released.	Live
Student results and trends	Each student sees their past results, their average and how their scores are changing.	Live
Self-mock practice	A student can practise on questions from exams they have already sat, once results are released.	Live
Report cards	Term reports built from a student's results, viewable by teachers, heads of department and the school admin.	Live
Department and school analytics	Pass rates by subject, by month and by department, so leaders can see which subjects are struggling.	Live
Integrity dashboard	Flagged exam sessions and writing-integrity flags in one place for heads of department and admins.	Live
Exam insight	For each test: which questions the class missed, the wrong answer most students chose, which students may need support and why, and how the class compares with its last five tests. Downloadable as a spreadsheet.	Live

External exams

Feature	What it does and what it means	Status
Organisation exams	A separate service for companies and groups to run one-off exams for their own respondents, with an exam code and password. It is not tied to a school.	Live

Coming next

Feature	What it does and what it means	Status
AI-suggested essay marking	The AI proposes a mark for each marking point, with the words from the essay that earned it, and flags where it is unsure. The teacher edits and saves. The AI never saves a mark, never sees a student's name, and runs only when a teacher asks. Off by default and switched on per school.	Planned

Feature	What it does and what it means	Status
Student results by topic	A student's own view of which topics they scored badly on, built from their exam results.	Planned
AI question drafting	The AI drafts test questions from a topic, for the teacher to review.	Planned

Smart Learning

For learning only: lessons, study, catch-up and reading. It acts on what Smart Assess finds but does not make or mark assessments.

Lessons and planning

Feature	What it does and what it means	Status
Lessons	A teacher builds a lesson in five steps (Engage, Explore, Explain, Elaborate, Evaluate, the "5E" model used in the national curriculum) and assigns it to a class. Students work through it at their own pace and their progress is recorded.	On per school
Check-your-understanding questions	Short questions inside a lesson. A teacher sees how each student did and which questions were missed.	On per school
Catch-up for absent students	A teacher records the day a lesson was taught. Students marked absent that day are offered the lesson as a catch-up, and the teacher sees who has caught up.	On per school
Coverage grid	Shows, by class and topic, which lessons have been taught and which classes are behind, so teachers and heads of department can see gaps. Downloadable as a spreadsheet.	On per school
Lesson plans	A teacher drafts a full plan using the national curriculum 5E template. An AI button drafts the plan from a subject, grade and topic, and the teacher reviews it. Plans can be organised in units and are private to their author.	Live
Shared lesson plan library	Teachers at different schools can browse and copy each other's published plans.	Live
Topics	One shared list of subject topics by grade. Teachers can propose a topic and heads of department approve, rename or merge them. Lessons, questions and games all point at the same topics.	On per school

Support for students

Feature	What it does and what it means	Status
AI tutor	A student can ask questions about a lesson they are working on. It has daily limits, students are told their teacher can read the conversation, and worrying conversations are flagged for an adult. The school decides whether it is on, and the principal can switch it off at any time.	On per school, optional
Tutor safety list	Conversations that raise a wellbeing or safety concern are collected for a teacher or principal to read.	On per school, optional

The Library

Feature	What it does and what it means	Status
Reading and listening	Students read books page by page or listen to audio recordings, and the Library remembers where they stopped. There is a shelf for books in the curriculum and a shelf for reading for fun.	Live, no books added yet
Curated centrally	Smart Assess Ja chooses and clears every title (public domain or openly licensed). Schools do not upload books. A title can only be published once its rights are confirmed.	Live
Reading assignments	A teacher assigns a book or a chapter to a class with a due date and sees who has finished it.	Live

Feature	What it does and what it means	Status
Bookmarks and notes	A student can bookmark pages and keep private notes. Teachers cannot read them.	Live
School controls	The school admin chooses which shelves and year groups see the Library, can switch audio off, can hide any title, and decides whether teachers may assign reading.	Live

Coming next

Feature	What it does and what it means	Status
Flashcards	Cards built from a lesson's key points and from questions a student got wrong.	Planned
Activities for different ability levels	Support, core and extension activities in lessons and lesson plans.	Planned
Results to catch-up loop	From a weak topic found in Smart Assess, assign a catch-up lesson or practice to the students who need it.	Planned
Offline and low-data use	Lessons and books that can be read with little or no internet.	Planned
Teacher resource space	A place to upload and organise teaching documents by class and topic.	Planned

Smart Play

For playing games only: quick, fun practice for the classroom. It does not replace formal assessment and it never holds the school's official results. Built and tested, held back until we choose to launch it. Manchester sees it as "coming soon".

Feature	What it does and what it means	Status
Topic Mastery	A student practises one topic at a time and watches their mastery of it grow.	Built, not switched on
Math Duels	Two students race through maths questions, one answering after the other, without needing to be online at the same moment.	Built, not switched on
Live quiz	A teacher hosts a quiz on the projector and students answer on their own devices, in the style of a classroom quiz show.	Built, not switched on
Jeopardy-style boards	A teacher runs a board of categories and points with a buzz-in, for individual students or teams.	Built, not switched on
Tug of War	Two teams pull a rope by answering quick questions, and every student appears on the field.	Built, not switched on
Rewards	Points (XP), day streaks, 18 badges and class leaderboards keep practice going. Teachers see badges on a class progress page.	Built, not switched on
Question management	A teacher builds their own game questions or imports many at once from a spreadsheet.	Built, not switched on
Its own sign-in	Play has a separate student and teacher sign-in so its data stays apart from exam data. Accounts are copied across from the school roster.	Built, not switched on

Coming later

Feature	What it does and what it means	Status
Challenges between students	Head-to-head and class challenges, then competitions between schools across the island.	Planned

School tools shared by all three

These are not part of Smart Assess, Smart Learning or Smart Play. They run the school itself, and the three products rely on them.

Feature	What it does and what it means	Status
Roles and portals	Separate home pages and menus for students, teachers, heads of department, school admins and principals, so each person sees only what they need.	Live
Attendance	Teachers register classes (start class, roll call). Heads of department see their own department's attendance. Principals see the live board and a truancy report.	Live
Attendance alerts	Principals and admins are alerted when a teacher is late or has not started class, or when a student marked present in the morning is missing from a class.	Live
Timetable	The school timetable by class or teacher.	Live
Teacher absence and cover	A teacher reports an absence, the system finds a free substitute for each class, and heads of department and admins review and fill any gaps. An absence can be cancelled.	Live
Staff messaging	Staff message each other directly or message the whole staff group.	Live
Classes and enrolment	Departments, subjects, classes, who teaches what, and which students are in which class. Year promotion and class changes.	Live
Staff and student management	Add people one at a time or from a spreadsheet. Password reset requests, active sessions and an activity log for the school admin.	Live
Principal and vice principal portal	A school-wide view: alerts, attendance, staff, students, and a read-only view of each teacher's work.	Live
Help assistant	A "?" chat helper that explains how the platform works. It cannot see anyone's account or data.	Live
Owner console	For Smart Assess Ja staff only: set up schools, switch features on per school, manage subscriptions and billing, and manage the Library catalogue.	Live

Words used in this guide

Word	What it means
HOD	Head of department. Reviews exams, sees their department's results and attendance, and also teaches classes.
Direct test or exam	A test a teacher sets and publishes to their own classes, with no approval step.
School exam (final exam)	A standardised exam written by a team lead, approved by the head of department and published to several classes.
Marking point	One thing a good answer earns marks for, with the marks it is worth. A short answer can have several.
5E	The five-step lesson model in the national curriculum: Engage, Explore, Explain, Elaborate, Evaluate.
Catch-up	A lesson offered to a student who was absent on the day it was taught.

Word	What it means
Coverage	Whether each class has been taught each topic.
Topic	A named piece of the curriculum for one subject and grade, for example "Simple interest, Grade 9". The shared topic list ties the three products together.
Integrity flag	A prompt for a teacher to look closer at something, such as switching tabs during an exam. It is never proof, and a person always decides.
Kiosk mode	The desktop app locking the screen to the exam while it is being sat.
Per-school switch	A setting the owner console turns on for one school at a time. A feature that is "on per school" is available only where its switch is on.

Statuses reflect the code as of 6 October 2026. Whether a given school has a feature switched on is a setting, so confirm it in the owner console before promising it.